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In the Margins: Asian American Poetry

In her collection of essays *How to Read Now*, Elaine Castillo interrogates the politics of reading, particularly how we read literature by writers of color. Drawing on her experience as a Filipina American writer, Castillo challenges not only how we read books but how we read other media, each other, and ultimately how we read the world. She calls to attention the harmful way the publishing industry and its readers approach writers of color “as flavors of the month, as heroic saviors, as direly important educators, ... as vessels of sensational trauma—but rarely as artist due the same depth and breadth of critical engagement as their white colleagues” (16). This demands more from writers of color. They aren’t allowed to be just artists they must also act as stand-ins for entire cultures. Rather than being allowed the freedom to experiment, fail, or simply create, they are expected to perform their identities on demand. Castillo also challenges the commonly held and naive belief that art—and specifically literature—builds empathy. She argues that while good intentioned this ideal perpetuates the passive, consumerist mode of engagement and as Castillo states, “if we need fiction to teach us empathy, we don’t really have empathy, because empathy is not a one-stop destination” (30). This belief leads not to more empathic people but to lazy readers. It makes reading a transactional exchange one that burdens and marginalizes people of color.

Elaine H. Kim finds and points out this same discrepancy in her essay *Defining Asian American Realities Through Literature*, “it’s hard to think of an Asian American writer who is not immediately identified as such, attesting to the continuing marginality of our literature.” (93). Asian American writers are rarely given the same privilege as their white counterparts whose work is not read from a racial lens but a universal one. This framing not only restricts how their work is interpreted but also continues the persistent narrative of otherness. Asian Americans often find themselves as the perpetual foreigner and at times even within our own community are we seen as outsiders. Kim further explains that “The Asian American writer exists on the margins of his or her own marginal community, wedged between the hegemonic culture and the non-English-speaking communities largely unconcerned with self-definition.” (88). Asian American writers exist in this complex in-between space, neither accepted into mainstream media nor entirely at home within their ethnic communities.

Now so far, I’ve been talking about the problems addressing how we read Asian American literature, meaning both its prose and poetry. However, focusing solely on poetry reveals a genre that refuses this mode of consumption. This paper argues that poetry’s emphasis on form, rhythm, and emotions along with its perceived difficulty makes it in a unique tool that allows Asian Americans to define themselves on their own terms. Prose is often viewed as more straightforward and easier to read than poetry whose artistic language and figurative language withholds easy understanding or narrative.

Although contemporary discussions often focus on Asian American prose, it is important to recognize that poetry has long been central to Asian American literary expression. Even

before the term "Asian American" was coined in 1968, poetry offered a powerful means for navigating the complexities of immigration, exclusion, war, and diaspora. As Juliana Chang notes, Asian American poetry dates back to the 1890s, with figures like Yone Noguchi and Sadakichi Hartmann—both Japanese-born poets and critics (83). Noguchi often is cited as the first Japanese-born writer to publish poetry in English while Hartmann was a critical in the formation of symbolist poetry. Asian American poetry continued to exist, but it wasn't until the 1960s and 1970s that it gained momentum as a political and literary force. The term "Asian American" had only just been coined in 1968 by student activists during a broader wave of civil rights and anti-war movements. Poetry played a key role in these racial and social struggles—poems were read at rallies, published in activist journals, and circulated within communities, serving, as Chang writes, as “an important vehicle for expressing the politicization of race” (81).

However, by the late 1970s and early 1980s, this strong poetic presence began to recede as prose fiction became the dominant mode for Asian American narratives. As Chang observes, prose gained prominence as “a prevalent means of circulating narratives of racial difference among a larger audience” (81). Prose, with its perceived transparency and marketability, became a preferred format for stories that were expected to teach, explain, or humanize racialized experiences. This emphasis on marketability and the commercialization of stories from marginalized authors reflects the deeper and problematic assumption that stories by marginalized authors should cater to and teach the dominant white audience as Castillo pointed out.

Theresa Hak Kyung Cha's *Dictee* serves as a prime example of the way Asian American authors use poetic form as a tool of resistance. Though categorized as prose, *Dictee* refuses traditional storytelling and defies any easy classification and instead embraces a ruptured, layered, and fragmented form. It falls in between prose and poetry much like Cha's own identity falls in between Korean and American. It is precisely this in-between, this nonfixed and fluctuating categorization, that Hyo K. Kim identifies as a powerful space of becoming. As Kim writes, "the hyphen that cleaves Korean and American is neither a site of contamination of more or less stable terms nor a dialectical resolution of opposites. Rather, *Dictee* theorizes it as a site (which should also be understood as a scene) of embodiment, wherein and through which the 'I' becomes constitutively open and made vulnerable to his or her individual and collective Others." (129).

What makes *Dictee* particularly powerful is its refusal to translate itself for the reader. Rather than offering a linear, coherent narrative that conforms to mainstream expectations of racial storytelling, *Dictee* is unapologetic experimental in form. Photographs remain uncaptioned, and the use of multiple languages—French, Korean, and Chinese—interwoven into the primarily English text, often appears without explanation or translation. These choices create a deliberately disorienting experience, one that demands to be felt as poetry often is. *Dictee* also demands the readers to interpret the text, mirroring the experience many immigrants as non-native English speakers go through when coming to America.

Contemporary poets have built upon Cha's work like Monica Youn's poem *Study of Two Figures (Pasiphaë/Sado)* which uses poetic language as a way to explore the complexity of

identity. Cha's Dictee nestled Greek figures within her text much like how Youn puts together the seemingly unrelated, Pasiphae the mythological Greek Queen and mother of the Minotaur with Prince Sado, the historical Korean prince who was killed by his father. The opening of the poem situates the two figures and draws connections between them:

One figure is female, the other is male.

Both are contained.

One figure is mythical, the other historical.

To the extent that one can be said to have existed at all, they occupy different millennia, different continents.

But, to the extent that one can be said to have existed at all, both figures are considered Asian—one from Colchis, one from Korea.

To mention the Asianness of the figures creates a "racial marker" in the poem.

This means that the poem can no longer pass as a white poem, that different people can be expected to read the poem, that they can be expected to read the poem in different ways.

To mention the Asianness of the figures is also to mention, by implication, the Asianness of the poet.

Revealing a racial marker in a poem is like revealing a gun in a story or like revealing a nipple in a dance.

After such a revelation, the poem is about race, the story is about the gun, the dance is about the body of the dancer—it is no longer considered a dance at all and is subject to regulation. (1-25)

Containers play a crucial role in both Pasiphae and Sado's stories, but containers and the idea of containment in this piece appear in both the literally / physical sense as well as is in the emotional or racial sense as later lines show "Asianness is a container in this poem // Race is a container in this poem". And in this poem the two figured being studied are contained. They cannot leave these containers of race, gender, desire, and suffering. However, Yu introduces two more figures the "tourist" and the "artist" both can enter and leave the containers that trap Pasiphae/Sado. Yu uses her position as artist/poet to open these containers and present their contents to us but even she is contained by her own mention of her race.

The only escape from this containment seems to come from the privilege of whiteness or white-passing. This is clear towards the end of the poem:

To mention race where it is not necessary to mention race is taboo.

I have not mentioned the race of the tourist or the artist.

The tourist and the artist are allowed to pass for white.

The tourist and the artist are not contained.

I have already mentioned the race of the poet.

Yu in her interview with Dorothy Wang states that "Whiteness is the privilege of not being contained in that way." And goes on to say, "I wanted the audience to be unsettled by this first poem [Study of Two Figures (Pasiphae/Sado)]... I want you to be questioning your

consumption of what you're reading, to understand how that implicates you and implicates me." (Wang). This ties back into Castillo's *How to Read Now: Essays* that point out the inheritance of reading that implicates all of us. Monica Yu and Theresa Cha works are just two examples of how Asian American poetry pushes back against the containment on the basis of race.

Timothy Yu is another contemporary poet and critic whose poetry fights back against the long-held notion of Asian silence and the model minority myth that perpetuates that silence. Yu's collection titled *100 Chinese Silences* is an expansion of his chapbook *15 Chinese Silences* which as Yu said in an interview with Lantern Review, began as parody and response to Billy Collins poem "Grave". In this poem Collins writes that his father's silence was "one of the one hundred kinds of silence // according to the Chinese belief," which Collins admits is something he just made up. Yu takes this phrase and turns it on its head it—writing poem after poem that confronts the racial and political silencing of Asian Americans. Throughout the collection Yu mimics and parodies the form of numerous poems and even some journalistic sources—from Billy Collins, Ezra Pound, to Tony Hoagland—and in doing so he investigates how Asia and Asians are portrayed in American poetry and culture. Chinese Silence No. 36 gives a series of absurd instructions for how to make or translate poetry from various cultures into English:

To make a Chinese poem in English we must allow the silence to creep in around the edges, to define the words the way the sky's negative space in a painting

defines the mountains.

—Tony Barnstone, *"The Poem Behind the Poem"*

To make a Japanese poem in English
we must allow the silence to creep up upon us
the way the ninja stalks and strangles
his unsuspecting victim.

To make an Indian poem in English
we must allow the waters of language to rise
and drown us like the Ganges until
we are reborn in a more accessible form.

To make a French poem in English
we must impale ourselves upon the Tour Eiffel
until our bloodcurdling screams evoke that sublime
je ne sais quoi.

To make a Spanish poem in English
we must let ourselves be gored by the charging bull
of poesy as we run like idiots through the streets

waving to our friends' cameras.

To make an American poem in English
we must level the mountains of language with dynamite
and in the rubble build an ethnic theme park
of charming accents and seething quiet.

To make an American poem Chinese
we must silence its creepy edges
and raise an iron-built mountain that mirrors
our own negation to us as if it were gold. (Timothy Yu, *Chinese Silence* No. 36)

In *Chinese Silence* No. 36, Timothy Yu directly challenges the kind of aestheticized and racialized thinking represented in the epigraph by Tony Barnstone which claims that “to make a Chinese poem in English we must allow the silence to creep in around the edges.” Yu uses Barnstone’s line of thinking as a starting point for his poem which evolves from this idea of how we should translate Asian poetry to English. Each stanza starts off with this repeating notion, and each time it becomes more ironic and satirical. Culminating in the final stanza in which Yu calls back to Barnstone and refusal the idea that silence just simply an artistic or aesthetic element of Chinese poetry but instead is imposed erasure.

In conclusion Asian American poetry refuses to be neatly contained or translated into easily digestible narrative. Poets like Theresa Hak Kyung Cha, Monica Youn, and Timothy Yu push back against the racial containment that seeks to define, fix, or silence them. Their works defy conventional expectations—both formally and thematically—embracing fragmentation, multilingualism, intertextuality, and parody. Their works also reveal that poetry often is an act of resistance—a space to explore and redefine identity, to discuss taboo topics, to break silences and most importantly a way to demand more from readers. These poets demand a more active and self-aware reader one who can sit with discomfort and ambiguity. The type of reader that Elaine Castillo urges us to be.

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